



MyGurukul

SACRED WISDOM — SATURDAY, FEBRUARY 14, 2026



SACRED TEXT

evam+vidhaiḥ kāla+citais tapobhiḥ |
parair* divaṃ* yānty* a+parair* nṛ+lokam |
duḥkhena mārgeṇa sukhaṃ* (hy* upaiti Ckṣiyanti) |
(sukhaṃ* Cduḥkhaṃ*)hi dharmasya vadanti mūlam | | 7.18 |
ity* evaṃ+ādi dvi+pa+indra+vatsaḥ |
śrutvā vacas* tasya tapo+ghanasya |
a+drṣṭa+tattva* *api na saṃtutoṣa |
śanair* idaṃ* ca*ātma+gataṃ* (babhāṣe Cjagāda) | | 7.19 |*

— Buddhacarita, Chapter 7, Verse 1

GURU'S INTERPRETATION

The Buddhacarita paints a vivid picture here, illustrating the diverse paths people take in pursuit of happiness and spiritual fulfillment. Some, through arduous ascetic practices, aim for heavenly realms, while others seek worldly pleasures in the human realm. The scripture subtly critiques the notion that extreme self-mortification is the only route to enlightenment, suggesting that even those dedicated to severe penance are still driven by a desire for ~~8A~~ happiness, albeit in a different form. It points out the inherent contradiction: seeking ~~8A~~ through a path of ~~8A~~ suffering.

The key lies in the verse's assertion that "suffering is the root of dharma," although other versions suggest "happiness is the root of dharma". Regardless, the young Siddhartha, the "lion among men," listens intently to the ascetic's words, yet remains unsatisfied. Even though he hasn't yet perceived the ultimate truth (a-drṣṭa-tattva), he intuitively senses something amiss. This shows us the importance of inner discernment, of not blindly accepting teachings, even from respected figures. Siddhartha's dissatisfaction is a testament to his burgeoning wisdom, his refusal to settle for superficial answers.

This passage speaks profoundly to your own spiritual journey. How often do you find yourself pursuing external validation or fleeting pleasures, believing they will bring lasting happiness? The scripture challenges you to examine your motivations. Are you truly seeking enlightenment, or simply trading one form of suffering for another? Are you imposing unnecessary hardship on yourself, mistaking austerity for genuine spiritual growth? Just as Siddhartha questioned the ascetic's path, you must question the patterns and beliefs that shape your life. True dharma, true understanding, isn't found in extremes, but in a balanced, compassionate approach to yourself and the world. The middle way, often discussed in Buddhism, avoids the extremes of self-indulgence and self-mortification, leading to a more sustainable and authentic path of growth.

Siddhartha's introspection reminds you that the answers lie within. It is through questioning, reflecting, and cultivating inner awareness that you can begin to discern the path to genuine liberation. Don't be afraid to challenge conventional wisdom or to trust your own intuition.

REFLECTION FOR TODAY

Are you willing to question the beliefs and habits that keep you trapped in cycles of suffering, even if those beliefs are widely accepted?